relatively expensive cigarette stub and boot marks, which indicated to them that the brigade commander's party was just ahead of them. The Chinese now stalked the Indians and approached the party undetected. Hoshiar Singh was at the head of the sixty-man party. He was being given a drink of water by one of the mess boys when he was shot dead. In the subsequent massacre, the three officers with the brigade commander were also killed along with another twenty-nine other ranks while the rest were wounded or captured. None from the party managed to escape.

The Chinese plan had been to capture Hoshiar Singh and the Chinese soldier who killed the brigade commander was severely punished. Realizing who he was from his red collar tabs, the Chinese announced that they had cremated the officer with full military honours. A few days later an officer from the Indian Embassy in Peking was called and the information was conveyed to him. However, this information proved to be incorrect as Hoshiar Singh's body was preserved in Phudung by the local Monpas. Much later, Indian army officers returned to Phudung and cremated the courageous soldier with his eldest son performing the last rites.

4 INFANTRY DIVISION AND 65 BRIGADE (DIRANG DZONG)

Brigadier A. S. Cheema's headlong flight in the wake of his GOC, Major General Anant Pathania, on the morning of 18 November has been documented in the earlier chapter. The brigade comprising 19 MLI and 4 Rajput now remained directionless in the absence of any instructions from its fleeing brigade commander or GOC. With the departure of the 4 Artillery Brigade commander as well, there were now no senior officers left to take charge of the situation in Dirang. The two infantry battalions under 65 Brigade were deployed outside the Dirang Dzong bowl, which by mid-morning was a scene of complete chaos.

There were still over a thousand troops left at Dirang Dzong, almost all of them quite willing to fight, each man awaiting orders which would never come for there was no one left to take charge of the situation. In comparison, there were but a handful of Chinese visible at Munna Camp, who every now and then would lob a few mortar rounds at the Indians hoping to scare them away.

Though the official history goes into the details of Indian counter-attacks, most eye-witness recollections suggest that a lot of it is exaggerated, especially the role played by 7 Cavalry. Major S. S. Brar from